



ASK A DOCTOR

What exactly is an “active birth”? Having an “active birth”—staying mobile during the first stage of labor and remaining upright, squatting, kneeling, or on all-fours during the second stage—can make labor and delivery easier and less painful. Working with gravity helps your pelvis to open and encourages the baby’s head to press on your cervix, helping it to dilate. To get active:

- **Practice [squatting](#):** it takes time to learn to do it, but it’s an effective way to speed labor up. When squatting, make sure you have sufficient support—from your partner, or by using a wall or the back of a sturdy chair.
- **Relax by kneeling** and facing forward with a birth ball or beanbag.
- **Use a birthing pool** if you want to relax in water for a while.
- **If you need an IV**, because you’ve been induced (see [Induction of labor](#)), ask for a mobile one so you can move around.
- **Choose a walking epidural**, which should enable you to stay active.
- **If lying down** makes your contractions stop, get up and start moving again.